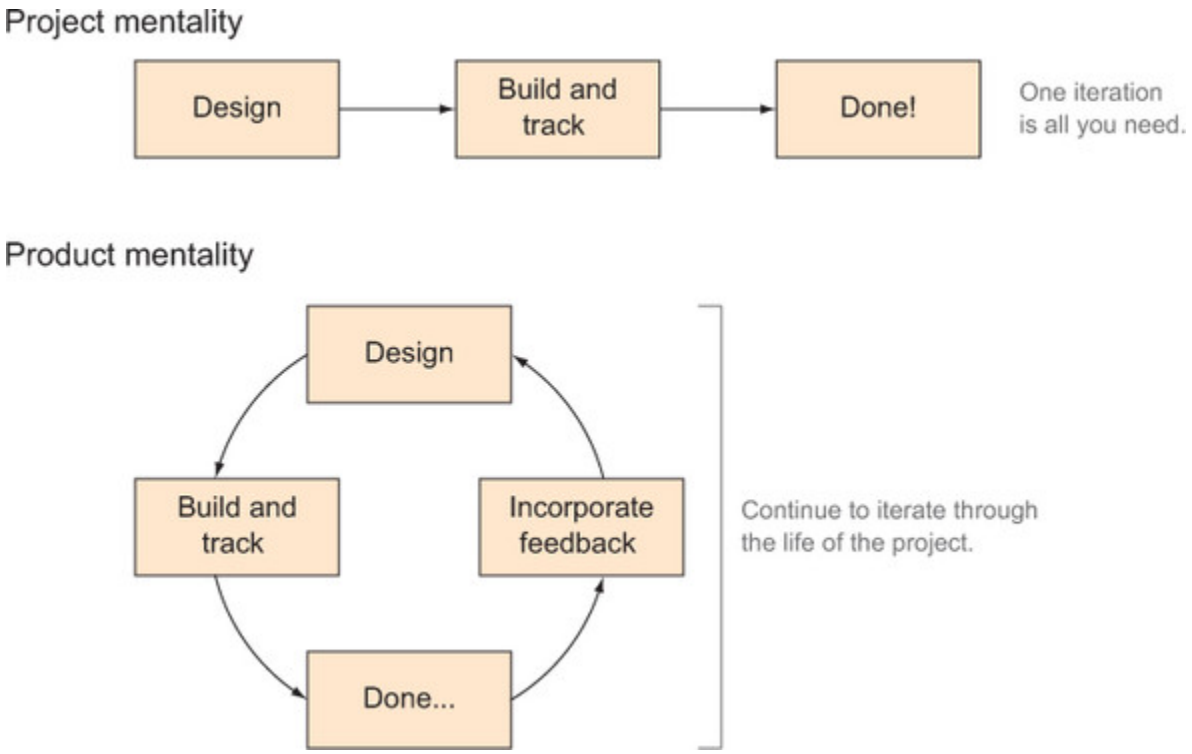
1.2.2. Problem: agile focuses on a product, not a project

One of the strengths of agile development methods is the idea that you are delivering a living *product*, not completing a *project*. A project is a defined set of time within which something is developed and tracked; a *product* is a living thing that continues to change to meet the needs of the consumer. This is shown in figure 1.2.

Figure 1.2. Project vs. product mentality



A good example of a project would be building a bridge. It gets designed, built to spec, and then it stands likely unchanged for a long time. Before you start the project you design exactly what you need so you can understand the total cost, and then you track the progress against the plan to make sure you stay on schedule and budget. This process is the art of project management.

A good example of a product is a mobile application geared toward runners that shows their paths on a map and aggregates their total mileage. It's a tool; you can run with it and get lots of data about your workouts. There are